

Naïve art and Primitivism

Primitivism was not a movement, more of a general desire to return to the less complicated art styles of some earlier cultures. Often characterized by a childlike simplicity in subject matter or technique, Primitivism grew from a European belief that non-Western and folk art was less civilized than modern, urban art. It was a romantic, nostalgic view, but as the sculptor Henry Moore (1898–1986) noted, the term implies lack of skill on behalf of the maker, but actually displays Western ignorance of the styles, beliefs and approaches of other societies.

Primitivism emerged in the simplified drawings and bold colours of Synthetism, but especially in Gauguin's first Tahitian paintings. In the 1890s, Henri Rousseau (1844–1910) was one of the first to paint in a naïve (childlike) style. By the early 1900s, several others were also exploring the naïve, simplifying their imagery to express innocence, originality and purity. These included Emil Nolde (1867–1956), Max Pechstein (1881–1955), Matisse, Modigliani, Picasso and sculptors Jacob Epstein (1880–1959) and Constantin Brancusi.



Rousseau, *Tiger in a Tropical Storm (Surprised!)*, 1891